Case study and Project topic:

“Beyond Bestsellers - Helping Fashion Shoppers Find Products That Fit Their Style and Budget.”

The main question to research:

How effectively do fashion e-commerce platforms help shoppers find products that are suited to their personal style, occasion and budget, and where could preference-based discovery improve the experience?

Problem statement:

Products that are trendy or popular are not necessarily the most suitable products that fit every single person or their budgets. The purpose of this case study is to explore how product discovery on fashion e-commerce sites supports personal style and budget, where friction occurs, and what could improve the experience.

Research approach:

I conducted a small-scale version of a comparative review of Myntra and Tata CLiQ Fashion from October 15-17, 2026. Using the same shopper goal, I attempted to find one Western top and one Indian top suitable for regular university wear, with a maximum budget of ₹1,500. I did not use the search bar or apply style-specific filters. Instead, I used each platform’s category navigation and available gender and price filters. During each journey, I recorded the navigation structure, filter precision, result breadth, merchandising cues and the amount of personal judgment required to identify a suitable product.

Shopper Criteria:

- University appropriate for regular wear
- Maximum price of ₹1,500
- Indian & Western top for diversity
- Versatile enough for repeated styling
- Personally suitable rather than chosen solely because of popularity or discount

My evidence Table:

Platform	What helped me	What frustrated me	What still required my judgment
Myntra	The Women menu clearly separated "Indian & Fusion Wear" from "Western Wear." There were many affordable basics and casual pieces, so I found both options relatively quickly.	The Western Tops results included many athletic-style products, requiring additional scrolling. Some product images appeared AI-generated, which made it harder to judge realistic fit and proportions.	I had to decide whether an item looked university-appropriate, inspect ratings and reviews, assess seller credibility, and estimate whether inexpensive fabric would actually be good quality.
Tata CLiQ	The website appeared organized, the category paths were clear, and its exact price ranges made the ₹1,500 budget easy to apply. I found both products in under five minutes.	The first visible ethnic-wear results leaned toward embroidered, traditional-looking kurtas rather than simple university wear. I had to scroll to find a subtler option.	I still had to interpret which pieces were appropriate for everyday university use. Several visible product cards also offered little review evidence for judging quality.

Finding 1: Categories narrowed the inventory, but not the shopper's intent

Although category and price filters reduced the number of products displayed, they did not fully capture the shopper's intended use. On Myntra, the Western Tops category contained affordable casual basics but also included numerous athletic-style products, requiring additional scrolling to find a university-appropriate option. On Tata CLiQ, the Ethnic Wear and Kurtis & Kurtas categories correctly matched the requested product type, but the initial results emphasized more traditional and embroidered styles rather than simple everyday university wear. This suggests that existing filters describe what a garment is, but not necessarily how, where or why the shopper intends to wear it.

Finding 2: Affordability did not eliminate quality uncertainty

Both platforms offered several products within the ₹1,500 budget, but price alone was not enough to create confidence in a purchase. On Myntra, the large number of inexpensive marketplace products made ratings, written reviews and seller credibility important when estimating fabric quality. Some product imagery also appeared digitally generated or heavily edited, making it more difficult to judge how an item might fit an ordinary shopper. Tata CLiQ appeared more curated, but several visible product cards displayed limited rating or review information. As a result, identifying an affordable product still required additional investigation and personal judgment.

Finding 3: Merchandising signals emphasized deals more than personal suitability

The most prominent product-card signals included discounts, price reductions, ratings and labels such as “Crazy Deal,” “Hot Picks” and “New Arrivals.” These cues helped communicate value and popularity, but they did not explain whether an item suited university wear, repeated styling or the shopper’s preferred level of traditionality. I therefore had to evaluate those qualities manually by examining the product images, silhouettes, reviews and descriptions. The experience suggests an opportunity to complement existing merchandising signals with information based on occasion, style preferences and intended use.

Products Selected During the Review

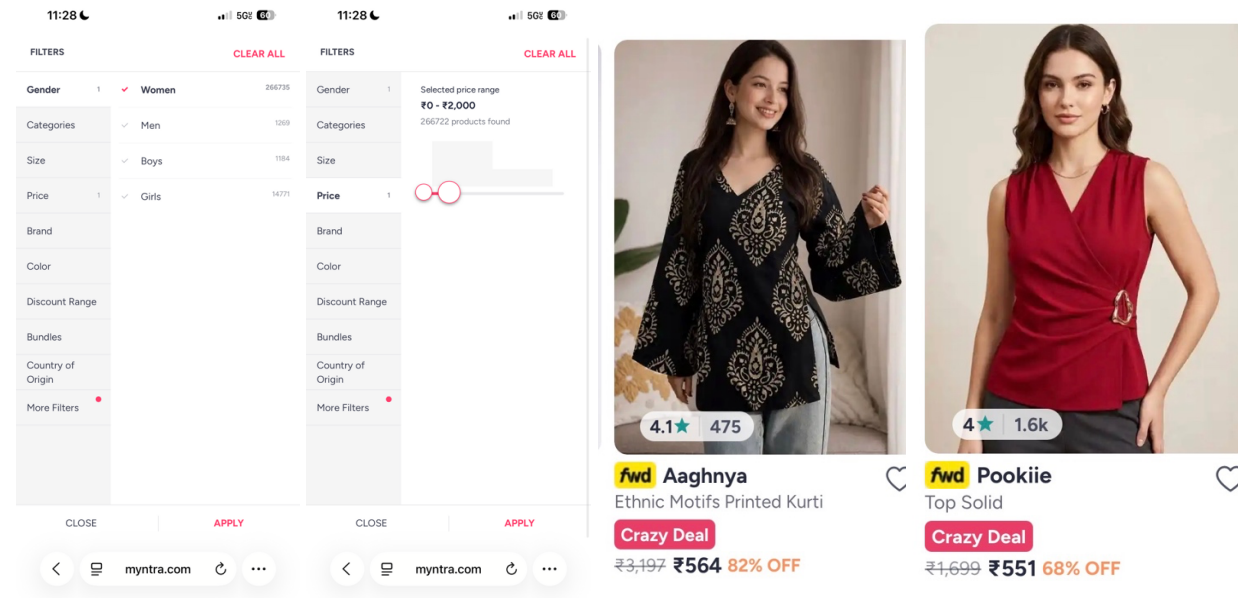
To compare the platforms under the same shopper goal, I selected one Western top and one Indian-wear top from each platform. These were not necessarily the most popular or heavily discounted products. I selected them because they most closely matched my criteria for affordable, versatile and university-appropriate clothing.

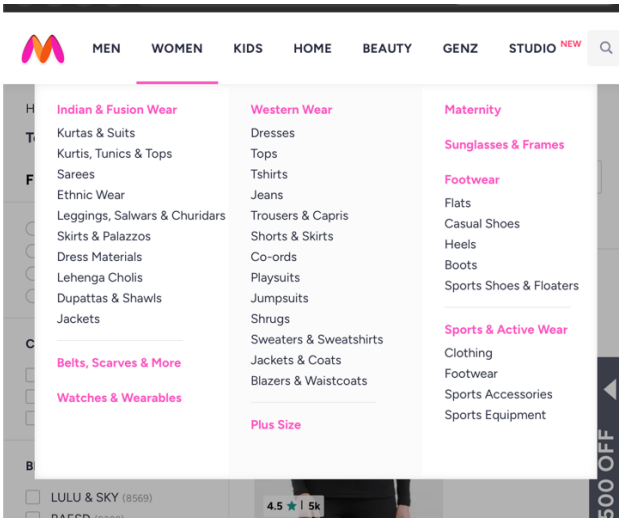
Platform	Selected product	Category	Price	Visible signals	Why I selected it
Myntra	Pookiie Solid Wrap Top	Western	₹551	4.0 rating, approximately 1.6K reviews, 68% discount	The simple silhouette appeared versatile for university and could be styled in multiple ways.
Myntra	Aaghnya Ethnic Motifs Printed Kurti	Indian wear	₹564	4.1 rating, 475 reviews, 82% discount	It was less formal and heavily traditional than many alternatives, making it more suitable for regular university wear.
Tata CLiQ	Wardrobe by Westside Black Solid Mock-Neck Top	Western	₹799	"New Arrivals," 5.0 rating based on one review	Its neutral color and basic silhouette made it suitable for repeated styling, although the single review provided limited quality evidence.
Tata CLiQ	Soch Pink Rayon Tunic	Indian wear	₹719	60% discount, price reduced by ₹449, no rating visible on the captured card	It was one of the simpler university appropriate options found after scrolling past more traditional styles.

- All four selected products were comfortably within the ₹1,500 budget, showing that affordability was not the primary difficulty. The greater challenge was identifying which affordable products matched the intended occasion, personal style and expected quality.

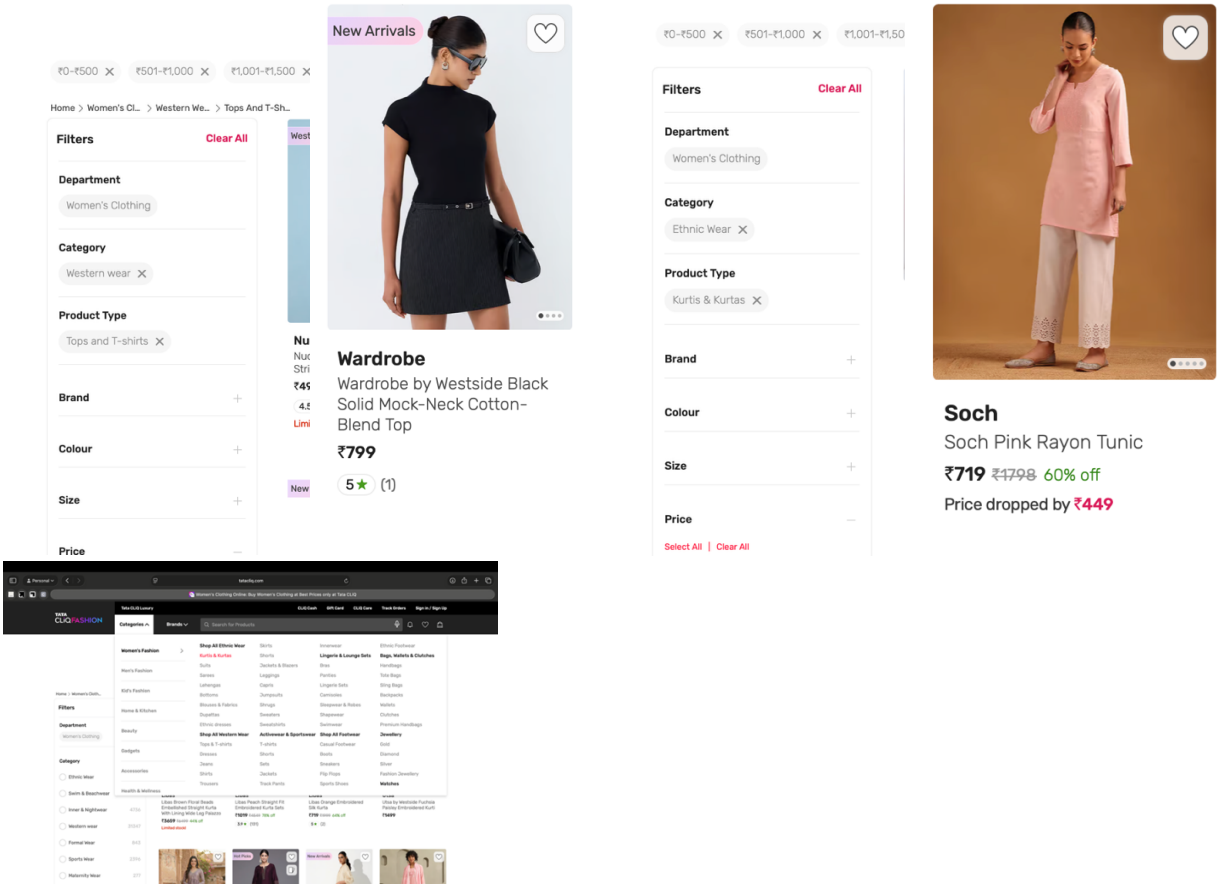
Visual Data:

1 – Myntra

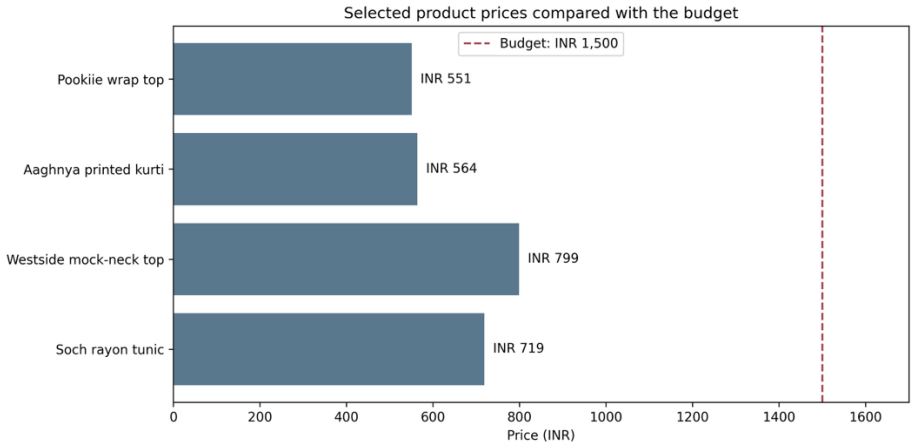




2 – Tata CLiQ



3 - Selected product prices and budget



(NOTE: these are selected examples, not a platform-wide price comparison)

Proposed Solution

I propose a preference-based product discovery experience that helps shoppers find tops suited to their intended occasion, style preferences and budget. My example shopper wants a chic, understated top for everyday university wear, with a preference for versatility and without overly corporate or heavily traditional styling. Both Western and Indian wear options remain eligible.

The proposed experience would exclude products above the shopper's maximum budget and then rank the remaining options using explicitly defined preference matching rules. Each suggestion would include a short explanation of why it matches the shopper's preferences, alongside any missing information that requires further checking.

Rather than replacing existing category, price, rating or merchandising systems, the concept would add another layer of discovery based on how and where the shopper intends to wear a product. This directly addresses the research finding that existing categories successfully identify what a garment is but do not always capture why a shopper wants it.

Prototype (Beyond Bestsellers)

To test this concept, I developed Beyond Bestsellers, a functional interactive prototype using Python, pandas, and Streamlit.

The prototype uses a small, manually curated dataset of eight example products from Myntra and Tata CLiQ. Users can specify a maximum budget, shopping category, intended occasion, preferred styles, styles they want to avoid, and whether they want to prioritize versatile pieces.

Products outside the selected budget and category are filtered out. The remaining products receive preference scores using transparent, explicitly defined matching rules. Each recommendation includes an explanation of the factors that contributed to its score, allowing the shopper to understand why the product was suggested.

The current prototype is intentionally rule based as of now October 2026 and does not use a trained AI or machine-learning model. It also does not connect to live retailer inventories or infer qualities such as comfort, fabric quality, or fit when reliable information is unavailable. These limitations keep the current system transparent while establishing a baseline that could later be evaluated against more advanced recommendation approaches.

Prototype Project link: https://varananananand-beyondbestsellers.streamlit.app

GitHub: Beyond Bestsellers repository

Key Takeaway

The comparative review suggested that affordability itself was not the primary difficulty. All four products selected during the research were comfortably within the ₹1,500 budget. The greater challenge was determining which affordable products matched the shopper's intended occasion, personal style, versatility needs and expectations of quality.

Building Beyond Bestsellers allowed me to translate that research finding into a working product concept. It also highlighted an important limitation of personalization systems: qualities such as comfort, fit, fabric quality, and real world appearance cannot always be reliably determined from limited product-card information.

A useful recommendation experience should therefore distinguish between what the system can confidently match and what the shopper still needs to verify.

Future Direction

A future version could explore AI-assisted matching between natural-language shopping requests and product information. For example, a shopper could describe what they want using language such as:

“Elegant university tops, not too formal, under ₹1,500.”

An AI-assisted approach could potentially interpret these more nuanced preferences while retaining strict requirements such as budget.

This functionality has not yet been implemented. Developing it responsibly would require a substantially larger product dataset and an evaluation process comparing its recommendation relevance with the current rule-based baseline.